The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Iranian state media say that peace talks between **America** and **Iran** have begun in Islamabad. Reports from Pakistan suggested the talks were face to face. America's vice-president, J.D. Vance, together with negotiators Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff, earlier met Pakistan's prime minister, Shehbaz Sharif. Meanwhile, Donald Trump said on social media that Iran is "losing big" in the six-week war.

Israel's armed forces say they struck more than 200 targets in **Lebanon** affiliated with Hizbullah, the armed group backed by Iran. Lebanon said at least ten people were killed. Israel's attacks complicate the peace talks in Islamabad, with Iran demanding the ceasefire with America apply to Israel's operations in Lebanon, too. The Lebanese and Israeli ambassadors in Washington are expected to meet on Tuesday.

Three supertankers passed through the **Strait of Hormuz**, a tentative sign that Iran may be easing its blockade of the waterway. Together the vessels can carry 6m barrels of crude. Mr Trump said on social media that the strait "will soon be open", and that empty ships are rushing to America to "load up".

The four astronauts on the **Artemis II** mission around **the Moon** returned safely to Earth, with a "textbook" splashdown in the Pacific Ocean. The mission's commander said all four crewmembers were in good shape. nasa says it wants to see more lunar missions, including the construction of a Moon base. A "proud" Mr Trump said "Next step, Mars!"

Taiwan's defence ministry said that it spotted 16 Chinese warplanes operating near the island on Friday just as Taiwan's opposition leader, Cheng Li-wun, was meeting **China**'s president, Xi Jinping, in Beijing. A senior Taiwanese official said the sorties showed that China was "sending out messages of peace, while… they continue to use military force to pressure Taiwan."

Sir Keir Starmer was forced to shelve legislation ceding sovereignty of the **Chagos islands** in the Indian Ocean to Mauritius. Donald Trump had strongly criticised the agreement; the islands include Diego Garcia, home to an American military base. British officials said they were not completely abandoning the plan, but that time had run out to pass it in this session of Parliament.

Japanese prime minister, **Takaichi Sanae**, took a break from political duties to welcome Deep Purple to **Japan**, more than 50 years after the band first toured there. Ms Takaichi's talents as a **heavy-metal drummer** are well documented. She said she had bought the group's album, "Machine Head", while still at school. Meeting Ian Paice, the band's drummer, she told him, "You are my god."

Word of the week: Boondoggle, what the International Thermonuclear Experimental Reactor has become. Read the full story.

Correction: In a previous edition of World in Brief we referred to Mojtaba Khamenei as an ayatollah. This was incorrect. He is a mid-ranking cleric.

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

The state of the strait

Since the ceasefire was announced on Tuesday, there has been little change in the number of ships braving the Strait of Hormuz, the international waterway that Iran has all but closed. In the absence of a formal published truce—and given that America, Iran and Israel cannot agree on what the current one covers—most vessels are biding their time. Iran announcing that it would continue striking foreign vessels in retaliation for Israeli attacks on Lebanon didn't help.

A mere handful of ships are making it through—and some only at great expense. The Islamic Republic is using its new-found control of the strait to charge a toll: ships that are not operated by Iran or its friends must pay up to $2m (for the largest oil tankers). How far Iran will try to maintain a similar scheme under a permanent peace agreement is unclear. The idea would have seemed outlandish before this war. But on Wednesday Donald Trump said: "We're thinking of doing it as a joint venture."

Photograph: Getty Images

A scrumptious run for the Red Roses

Can anyone stop England’s all-conquering Red Roses? The women’s rugby union team have won 33 consecutive matches, including the World Cup final in September. They have also been the victors of the last seven iterations of the Six Nations, an annual contest between England, France, Ireland, Italy, Scotland and Wales. The Red Roses’ first match of the 2026 tournament is against Ireland on Saturday.

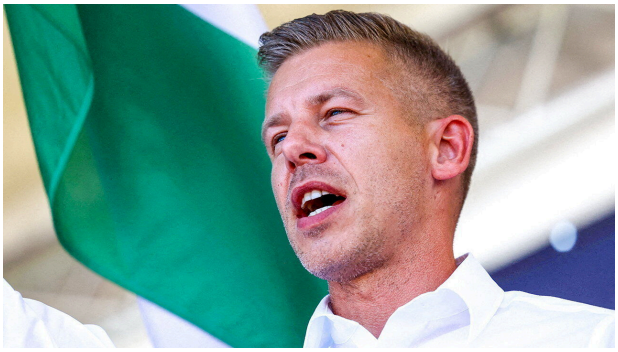
The Roses have recently had to make important changes: three players are pregnant, including Zoe Stratford, the captain. Emily Scarratt, who has scored more points for England than anyone else, and star winger Abby Dow both retired in 2025. But the English have an extraordinary talent pool to draw from. Centre Meg Jones is an experienced substitute for Ms Stratford as captain. Claudia Moloney-MacDonald, a winger who can also play scrum-half, will replace Ms Dow. Ms Moloney-MacDonald will also face a very familiar opponent: her wife, Cliodhna, will make her 50th appearance for Ireland.

Photograph: Reuters

Sakura season comes to Washington

In 1912, the first lady of the United States and the wife of Japan's ambassador to America planted a pair of cherry trees on the north bank of the Tidal Basin in Washington, dc, right next to the National Mall. Today such trees line the 107-acre Basin, and Washington, like Japan, celebrates with blossom festivals.

This weekend is the Japan-America society's festival, Sakura Matsuri, held on Capitol Hill; it claims to be "the largest celebration of Japanese culture" in America. More sedate Japanophiles can attend cultural demonstrations, including Taiko drumming and sumo wrestling. The festival will also feature k-Pop performances and a "Japan Smart Infrastructure Pavilion", guaranteed to drive Americans who like fast trains and clean, functional commuter-rail networks into paroxysms of jealousy. All this conviviality will be a welcome change from recent bilateral tensions. Earlier this week Donald Trump complained that Japan had not done enough to help America in its war against Iran.



Photograph: Reuters

Peter Magyar, the man who might unseat Viktor Orbán

At a recent rally in Pásztó, a small town in northern Hungary, Peter Magyar drew a sizable crowd as he campaigned for local candidates from Tisza, the party he leads. Since emerging onto the political scene in early 2024, Mr Magyar has spent months touring the country and building his organisation from scratch. Tall, handsome and charismatic, he projects a modern image that contrasts with Hungary's more traditional political class.

The 45-year-old has established himself as the most serious challenger to Viktor Orbán, who has dominated Hungarian politics for more than a decade and a half. Mr Magyar first gained attention by posting videos accusing Fidesz, the ruling party, of corruption, including attempts to cover up a child-abuse scandal. Within months, Tisza won roughly 30% of the vote in elections to the European Parliament.

A trained lawyer, Mr Magyar has worked in Berlin, Hamburg and Brussels. He used to move within Fidesz's political orbit, holding roles linked to Hungary's representation in the European Union. That insider status gives him direct exposure to how power is exercised at the top of government and lends credibility to his accusations of corruption—something earlier opposition figures, more easily cast as outsiders, struggled to achieve.

His break with Fidesz also appears to have been shaped by personal ambition. Party insiders had long viewed him as ill-suited for senior roles, and he never secured the prominence he sought within the system. Some also suggest that his frustration was sharpened by the greater political success of his ex-wife, Judit Varga, a former justice minister and close ally of Mr Orbán.

In policy terms, Mr Magyar offers less of a clean break with the status quo than his rhetoric suggests. Tisza's programme remains broadly centre-right, with positions on migration and economic policy that overlap with those of Fidesz. The clearest distinction lies in foreign policy: Mr Magyar has pledged to repair relations with the EU and unlock frozen funds, which would provide relief to Hungary's struggling economy. At home, his campaign has focused more on governance than ideology—highlighting corruption, weak economic performance and the deterioration of public services such as health care.

For many voters, support for Mr Magyar is driven less by conviction than by exhaustion with Mr Orbán's long rule. Whether that is enough to unseat him on Sunday's election will depend on how many Hungarians are willing, finally, to vote for change.

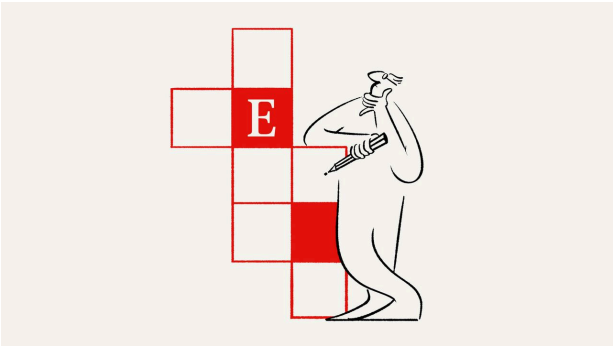


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Keen to be included in the age requirement (5)

2 across - The Irish expel royal successor (4)

3 across - The night before, not excluding ring ceremony (5)

1 down - Rare is the beguiling appearance of our planet beyond the moon (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Enthusiastic, hankering (5)

2 across - Next in line or beneficiary (4)

3 across - Gathering, occasion (5)

1 down - (Picture of) our home ascending from the horizon of the Moon (9)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Emilio Ferreira, Buenos Aires, Argentina

Adele & Ted Pelletier, Portland, Oregon

Frank Janssen, Brussels, Belgium

They all gave the correct answers of: Christine Lagarde, the Greens, Carrie Fisher, Salem and The Dead. The theme is Stephen King novels: Christine, The Green Mile, Carrie, 'Salem's Lot and The Dead Zone.

The questions were:

Monday: Who is the President of the European Central Bank?

Tuesday: Which political party won the largest shares of the vote in the recent Baden-Wũrttemburg regional election?

Wednesday: Which actress played Princess Leia in the Star Wars films?

Thursday: In which Massachusetts town did witch trials occur in 1692-93?

Friday: Which short story by James Joyce was the last, and longest, in his Dubliners collection?

The only reason for being a professional writer is that you can’t help it.

Leo Rosten